

When people talk about how ChatGPT uses water, how is that harmful against the environment?

Posted by u/Puzzleheaded_Sir800 • 0 points • 4 comments

I personally don't use ChatGPT but everytime online someone uses it, the comments mention how water is literally destroyed in the process.

When I hear about water being used for energy I think of like hydraulic dams using water, but that doesn't pollute the water

or if they use it for like the matter, doesn't the water evaporates turning into a gas, and then which eventually will get sucked into a get into a rain cloud which eventually becomes rain?

Just want to know to make my carbon footprint less permanent.

Comments

u/New_Line4049 • 1 points • 2026-02-10 00:46 UTC

The water isnt destroyed, the real problem is they need very clean water, like.... the kind you might want to drink. It takes huge amounts of energy to clean and desalinate that water, and once it falls as rain youve gotta do it all sgain to make it usable again.

The other thing is, if you take water our of a salt water source and desalinate it, it tends to increase the concentration of salt in the place you took water from, at small scale that might not be a problem, but if youre taking huge amounts of water it can significantly change the concentration of salt, which is a problem for anything living in that water.

u/Delehal • 1 points • 2026-02-09 22:20 UTC

>or if they use it for like the matter, doesn't the water evaporates turning into a gas, and then which eventually will get sucked into a get into a rain cloud which eventually becomes rain?

That's correct. The water is not destroyed. It is evaporated and returns to the natural water cycle. That doesn't mean water is free, though. At any given point in time, we only have so much drinkable water available in any given area. There are some places where a new data center moves in and suddenly the town is facing a water shortage and prices shoot up.

Some of this is because data centers are expanding rapidly, far more rapidly than anyone would have predicted 10 or 20 years ago. The amount of water used by data centers is basically going to double

within just a few years.

Another part of this is that data centers are being approved by an inconsistent patchwork of local regulations at city and county levels, but the projects have industrial needs that can affect much more than just the town they move into. These sorts of projects can have an impact at systemic scale and they aren't really being planned or permitted that way.

u/mugenhunt • 2 points • 2026-02-09 22:04 UTC

The water cycle does mean that the water is still somewhere on Earth, but it's probably not going to be in a place where we have access to it. If that cloud of vapor rains into the ocean, we're not going to be able to use that water without a lot of extra energy being used to purify it.

It's less about wasting water, and more about wasting water that has already been made drinkable for humans.

u/AgentElman • 2 points • 2026-02-09 22:01 UTC

All datacenters, not just AI datacenters, use a total of about 4% of water used.

So it is far less harmful to the environment than the things that use the other 96% of water used.

Complaining about AI water use is like looking at a freeway full of cars burning gas and pointing to 2010 Honda Civics and complaining that they are using gas.